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Girl Child Day 2018

Inspiring day for teenage girls

BRAC celebrates the National Girl Child Day in October every year in order to highlight the inequalities faced by majority of girls in the country and to promote awareness about girl child rights.

This year, 2018, the Government of Bangladesh has declared 10 October as National Girl Child Day with the theme ***'থাকলে কন্যা সুরক্ষিত, দেশ হবে আলোকিত'*** (Protecting girls lead to an enlightened nation).

Violence against girl child is still a critical challenge for Bangladesh. Despite social awareness, other contributing factors such as slow-moving legal processes, uncertainty of availing legal justice and inability to ensure accountability of law enforcement stimulate violence against girl child. Child marriage appears to be a major apprehension which leads a teenage mothers to birth a stunt baby. It also triggers malnourishment for both of them. Sometimes they pay it off by death.

To create a social movement for protecting the rights of the girl child, BRAC undertook a series of activities. It organised discussions, workshops, popular theatres at local and national level. The main objectives of these events were to raise awareness on the pressing factors of persistent discrimination against the girl child. Prevalence of sexual harassment, child marriage, patriarchal structure and its impact on the girl child were the main highlighted areas.

Furthermore, it was emphasised how education and skills can contribute to build an enlighten nation. It directly leverages the economy of the nation. Also, the protection mechanism of government for girl child was discussed. The major point of Child Marriage Restraint Act and other government initiatives to retain girl child in education system were highlighted. National help line number was also promoted so that people can seek assistance in emergency situation.

A supplement regarding this day has been published by the Daily Samakal and the Daily Jugantor. Where Anna Minj, Director CEP, IDP and GJD highlighted that half of the population of this country are women. Without active participation of these people, overall development of the country is not likely to be achieved. So, economy, education, heath, politics etc. in every field, equal participation of women and men is prerequisite for sustainable development.

She also mentioned our failure to protect the girl child's rights. They are still experiencing violence from their family and the society. Now is time for creating an enabling environment for the girl child. Like the state, this responsibility also goes to the family and the individual person in the society. Child marriage is the biggest challenge in Bangladesh; sufferers are mainly the girl child. But the fact is attaining the international Sustainable Development Goals and GoB 7th five year plan is the precondition to curb child marriage rates.

Though Bangladesh has achieved many human development index, unfortunately it is struggling to achieve the desired success in child marriage. Education, skill and employment opportunity can decrease the child marriage rate. Overall we have to increase investment in state level, ensuring strict enforcement of the law and social awareness to decrease child marriage. http://epaper.jugantor.com/2018/10/10/

Ministry of Women and Children Affairs arranged rallies where BRAC participated to protest against the prevailing gender discrimination. The Government also observed 'Child Marriage Prevention Day' on 9 October 2018 with civil society representatives. Ministry of Women and Child Affairs and other civil society organisation were of this celebration where a human chain was made in front of the National Press Club. BRAC Community Empowerment Programme and Girls Not Brides participated in this human chain.

Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade (DFAT), in association with BRAC organised a motivational programme for teenage girls to celebrate the International Girl Child Day on 11 October at the Australian High Commission. The theme of the event was 'With Her: Motivating the Girl Force through Sport'. Adolescent girls from the BRAC Education Programme, BRAC Meyeder Jonno Nirapod Nagorikotto (MEJNIN) and Technology Enabled Girl Ambassadors (TEGA) were part of this programme. The programme was focused on Girls in Sports. The participants met Bangladesh national sports women who were pioneer and who faced multiple challenges and made their own history in the most male dominated field of different sports. DFAT invited Bangladeshi eminent sports women from diverse ground. Table tennis player Zobera Rahman Linu, women's team cricketer Shathira Jakir Jesy, Bike rider Atiqua Roma, Wrestler Sherin Sultana, Weightlifter Mabia Akhtar, swimmer

Mafuza Akter Sheela and Sports Journalist Fariha Afsana Kanta attended the event. A motivational clinic was organised where teenage girls split up into groups and the sportswomen shared their life stories of reaching out their goal which they dreamt out. In the motivational clinic, these champions shared their struggles and strategies to overcome their challenges to meet their goals. The Australian Chargé de' Affairs to Bangladesh, H E Penny Morton, hosted the event and recognised these sports women with a certificate to honor their leadership in girls' sports.

'From my childhood I went through many obstacles for being a woman. But I never saw myself as inferior to men in confronting the challenges. I think confidence, target and courage can conquer any challenges and strive to reach our desired goal.'

Zobera Rahman Linu is a Bangladeshi table tennis player. She won a record 16 national championships during 1979–2001. She received Bangladesh National Sports Award in the table tennis category in 1999.

People were talking on my dress, my work and spoke badly to my parents. My parents never paid any attention to them and I have confidence upon myself that one day I will be the reason of their 'pride' if I could reach my goal. Now, these people admire me and I am a role model to many. You need to be determined always to reach your goal.

Mabia Akter, Bangladeshi Weightlifter, won gold medal in the women's 63 kg weight class at the 2016 South Asian Games.

Throughout my career as sports journalist, I have experienced that sponsors invested less in women sports rather than men– this discrimination has a huge negative effect on women sports career. This needs to be addressed properly.

Fariha Afsana Kanta, Sports Journalist, Maasranga Television.

The stories were a true reflection of women empowerment by breaking away from the patriarchal norms through creating their own identity with their merit, courage and mostly confidence. The women champions experienced discrimination throughout their life cycle started from family to society but they didn't give up. They developed their own ways to fight against the gender discrimination, stereotyping structure and finally succeeded.

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